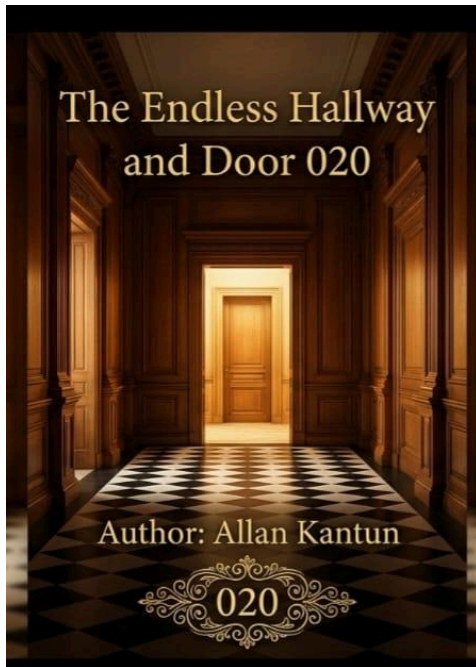


“The Endless Hallway and Door 020 ”



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SYNOPSIS:

You wake up in an unknown hallway.

A door at the end.

The number 020.

Every time you leave, the hallway changes.

The mirrors watch.

Shadows follow your steps.

And when you finally cross door 020, you will discover that you weren't looking for an exit, but a memory.

Part I: The Endless Hallway

It was a rather strange night.

The weather was cool, with a faint but almost endless rain, and inside the house, the heat felt somewhat unbearable.

After a long day at work, spending hours in front of the computer screen, the rain caught me by surprise just as I was heading home.

But finally, I could breathe in the tranquility of my home...

or so I thought.

The rain continued for hours.

There were few options to fight the boredom, and the heat didn't help at all.

So the only viable option was to take a long shower and try to sleep early, only to wake up the next day and start it all over again.

I remember pouring myself a glass of water with a couple of ice cubes to leave by my nightstand.

I had a book I hadn't been able to finish yet, but for some reason, tonight I didn't feel like continuing.

So I simply lay down...

and tried to fall asleep.

Without much success.

At least for a couple of hours.

The rain kept falling.

Suddenly, I found myself in a strange hallway.

It looked like the hallway of an old hotel, with a very 1960s-style atmosphere.

There was music.

A soft, melodic jazz, with a rhythm...

but I couldn't identify where it was coming from.

It was simply there, in the air.

There were mirrors on the hallway walls.

Mirrors that reflected nothing...

only darkness.

The black and white floor tiles marked the path in two directions.

Exactly twelve steps away, the hallway split: to the left, a white door, worn by time, with the number 020.

At the far end, to the right...

a door that read: emergency exit.

Desperation didn't take long to set in.

I tried to call for help.

I asked, I shouted...

but nobody answered.

I knocked on the door a couple of times.

Then harder.

I asked if anyone was inside.

Nothing.

I tried to force it open...

but it didn't budge.

Then, I heard them.

Whispers.

Faint voices.

Distant echoes I couldn't quite understand.

Panic began to seep, little by little, into my mind.

I ran toward the emergency exit once more.

Part II: The Creature and the Mirrors

I turned the doorknob.

I crossed the threshold...

and I appeared right back at the beginning.

The same hallway.

The same mirrors.

But now...

room 020 was on my right.

Confused, I tried to keep my calm.

It's a dream, I thought.

A nightmare.

I just need to wake up...

But how?

While I tried to find a logical explanation, the music changed.

It became more intense.

Closer.

It seemed to come from room 020.

A chill ran down my spine.

I wasn't alone.

I advanced slowly toward the door.

Step by step.

Then I noticed it.

The lights had changed.

They were no longer warm...

now they had a reddish, dim, sickly hue.

The mirrors were different too.

Some were still empty.

Dark.

Deep.

But others...

weren't.

One, right in front of door 020, showed a dull, blurry reflection.

And another, next to the emergency exit...

distorted the image, stretching it out, like those funhouse mirrors.

The anguish grew heavier.

The questions in my mind no longer made sense.

And yet...

My damn curiosity pushed me toward the exit again.

I turned the doorknob.

I crossed the threshold.

And once more...

The beginning.

But the hallway changed again.

The air was colder.

Much colder.

The lights were now a more intense red.

Some hung from the walls, as if they had been struck...

but they were still on.

This time, the whispers were clearer.

Laughter.

Voices.

Conversations...

that I couldn't understand.

The mirrors' frames...

had changed.

They were no longer the same.

Some were rectangular.

Others, oval.

As if reality itself were warping.

And at the end of the hallway...

that mirror...

The one that always faced me upon crossing the exit...

It no longer showed my reflection.

Only a shadow.

A silhouette.

My mind tried to cling to logic.

It's just my reflection, I told myself.

Nothing more.

But panic...

did not agree.

Suddenly, the music stopped on the other side of the door.

It was as if someone had changed the station on an old radio.

The static in the air was undeniable.

Like tiny pulses of electricity surrounding my body.

A cold panic dripped from my forehead.

The terror I felt at that moment was unbearable.

Fear forced me to turn toward one of the mirrors.

No matter how much I resisted...

no matter how much I refused...

An impulse controlled my body.

Darkness.

Only darkness could be seen inside the mirror.

Suddenly, the music began to play again.

This time, faster.

More intense.

The band played as if it were a huge party...

on the other side of door 020.

A small echo interrupted my delirium.

Footsteps.

Very close to me.

I peeked down the hallway...

but there was no one.

The footsteps continued, louder and louder.

As if someone were marching...

in a military cadence.

Closer.

And closer.

My eyes didn't seem to work fully...

but my ears caught every thundering step.

Then I saw it.

A shadow began to outline itself on the floor tiles.

Elongated.

Deformed.

As if something...

far too big...

were approaching.

Fear exploded inside me.

I ran.

Without looking back.

I ran toward the emergency exit once more.

But before leaving...

something caught my attention.

It was just a split second.

Like when you see something out of the corner of your eye.

I wasn't sure.

Maybe it was my imagination.

I couldn't stop.

The shadow on the floor was getting closer and closer.

And, on the verge of panic, I crossed the door.

And once more...

The beginning.

The same starting point...

or so I thought.

This time, the hallway was different.

Much darker.

Very few lights remained on.

A single lamp flickered weakly, while the others were completely dead.

It was like being inside an abandoned hotel.

Forgotten.

Dust covered the floor.

Mold crawled up the walls, as if it had devoured the entire place.

The mirrors remained dark.

But something had changed.

The two mirrors on the sides of the hallway were shattered into pieces, scattered across the tiles.

And the mirror at the end...

That one hadn't fallen.

It had an impact mark.

A deep crack, as if someone had tried to break it...

without succeeding.

I approached slowly.

I had to check.

I had seen it.

It couldn't have been my imagination.

On the other side of the mirror...

There was something.

A silhouette.

Dark.

I can't say for sure that I saw it clearly...

But I felt it.

I felt its gaze pierce into the deepest part of me.

Like a sharp stab straight to the chest.

Then, the music interrupted everything again.

Now it sounded distorted.

Choppy.

Like a vinyl record at the end of its track...

When the needle skips over and over again.

And right at that moment...

A sound.

Sharp.

Small.

Something fell.

I turned around slowly.

A tiny shard of glass...

Had just broken off from the mirror.

I took a step toward it.

Then another.

And then I felt it again.

That sharp stab.

That sensation.

As if someone...

Were watching me.

I faced my fear and stood before the broken mirror.

I could barely recognize myself in it.

I couldn't tell if it was because of the cracks, or because my mind was already playing tricks on me...

or because sanity had decided to abandon me.

The same heavy footsteps of that creature were heard again.

This time, accompanied by a heavy...

suffocated panting.

Without warning, the entire place shook.

An earthquake, perhaps...

impossible.

The few lights that still worked began to flicker relentlessly.

A high-pitched sound tortured my ears.

With my hands on my head, kneeling on the floor...

everything trembled.

The mirrors began to shatter one by one.

And behind me...

I felt it.

The creature, panting, getting closer and closer.

With no escape left, I ran toward the emergency exit again.

And as I opened it...

there it was.

The creature.

A tall, deformed being, with a disproportionate body...

like a troll or a gray ogre over two or three meters tall.

Its long hair covered part of its disfigured face.

A horrific, gut-wrenching scream came out of its mouth as it extended its long arms toward me.

I backed up a couple of steps and, luckily, managed to dodge it.

And there it stood.

Between the exit and me.

The creature let out another gut-wrenching scream...

like the lament of thousands of years eating away at a man's soul.

And in that tiny fraction of a second...

I saw my chance.

I slipped past the side of its body until I managed to cross the threshold.

And then...

I was back in the same hallway.

But now everything had changed.

Everything had gone back to normal.

An ordinary, everyday hallway...

of a hotel.

Everything had gone back to normal...

or so it seemed.

The lights worked.

The mirrors were no longer shattered.

There were no creatures.

No shadows.

But still...

I felt uneasy.

Alert.

Anxious.

Everything was silence.

An absolute silence.

With no sign of life around me...

other than my own.

Once more, I approached the room door.

It was still locked.

On the other side...

nothing.

Only silence.

In my desperation, I couldn't take it anymore.

I banged on the door.

I tried to kick it.

I pushed with all my strength.

But I couldn't even splinter the wood.

I pressed my fists and forearms against the door.

My forehead pressed against it...

And I began to cry.

The desperation, the anxiety, the uncertainty...

and the fear.

Oh, the fear.

It was there...

curled up in my chest, squeezing my heart.

"Damn it!" I screamed in desperation, on the verge of exhaustion and agony.

My mind couldn't take any more.

"Please..." I shouted, "help... please... anyone..."

I struck the door once more with my bare hands.

But nothing.

Until, from the other side...

a voice.

Very faint.

"No... not for now."

"Hello... help... please..." I shouted a third, fourth, and fifth time.

Then, it happened.

Water began to seep from under the door.

Very cold water.

The hallway began to flood.

Again, the lights flickered.

The water was rising fast.

It had already reached a level above my knees.

It was cold...

very cold.

Like the water at the bottom of a frozen lake.

As best as I could, I reached the exit door once more.

With my hand on the doorknob...

I stopped.

Again?

Another loop in circles?

My mind filled with questions...

but found no answers.

My body trembled between desperation and the coldness of the water, which was rising level by second.

I reacted.

I was still holding the doorknob.

The water was already up to my neck.

And then I noticed it.

It was salty.

Bitter.

Heavy.

Like swimming against an invisible current.

At the last moment...

I simply closed my eyes.

And let it submerge me.

My hand slowly let go of the doorknob.

I saw my life flash before my eyes.

I was falling.

The water was dragging me to the bottom.

Part III: Room 020

But then...

I woke up.

I let out a gasp under the water.

Full of fury...

and desire.

I opened the door.

And it was like being sucked in by a current...

a whirlpool.

Dropped.

Tired.

On my knees.

But alive.

Alive...

though trapped in the hallway.

While I questioned everything...

with no clear answers.

Awake.

I find myself lying on the floor of the same hallway.

The tiles still hold small puddles of water.

So...

Was it real?

I don't think I can take any more.

This back and forth.

Spinning in eternal circles.

With more questions than answers.

A labyrinth with no exit.

I just want to open that door.

Go in.

Get out of here.

I repeated that to myself over and over inside my mind.

I needed to calm down.

Breathe.

Get up.

As best as I could, I pushed myself up on my arms and managed to get onto my knees.

With my head down.

My hands clenched into fists.

Squeezing them with all my strength.

Holding back tears.

Trying to breathe.

Trying to soothe the chaos inside my mind.

Finally, I managed to stand up.

I wiped away my tears with my arm.

And took a step forward.

As I raised my gaze...

I saw it.

A shadow.

On the other side of the mirror.

A creature with glowing red eyes.

Watching me.

Smiling.

It didn't move a single inch.

It didn't make a sound.

It just smiled.

I took a deep breath.

I held its gaze.

And I passed right in front of it.

Without fear.

Without rush.

I simply walked past the mirror.

Without looking down.

Straight toward the exit door.

Then something happened.

The smile began to fade slowly.

And the intense red of its eyes...

went out.

Like an ember consumed by time.

I took the doorknob.

I opened the door once more.

And crossed the threshold.

Back in the same place.

But now there was a change.

Everything was different again.

It was as if the air were less heavy.

Calmer.

Easier to breathe.

The mirrors and lights seemed normal.

Back in that strange hallway looking like a 1960s hotel.

This time I tried door number 020.

I knocked a couple of times.

Nothing.

I simply turned around to reset the scene.

Because that's how it felt.

Like a labyrinth of resets.

Over and over again.

I took a step...

and collapsed against the wall.

I had lost my strength.

I ended up sitting on the floor, next to the white door.

The frustration.

The fear.

The fatigue.

I tried to hold back my tears with what little strength I had left.

But it wasn't enough.

I simply cried.

I cried so bitterly that, amidst my tears, I tasted again the waters that had flooded the hallway some twenty loops ago.

I cried until I couldn't anymore.

And I fell asleep.

God knows how long I remained unconscious.

When I woke up, I was still tired.

Dejected.

I stood up and began to walk once more toward the exit.

This time I could see my own reflection in the mirrors.

The image of a tired man.

Defeated.

Every step hurt.

Every thought hurt.

Every heartbeat hurt.

I didn't know how much longer I could go on like this.

What little hope I had left was slowly fading.

And it hurt.

But I didn't want to end up there forever.

Just as I was about to open the exit door, I heard something.

Voices.

Laughter.

Joyful sounds.

I ran back toward the door.

I knocked hard.

"Hello? Is anyone there? Help!"

Nobody answered.

The voices vanished.

Only silence remained.

Once more I crossed the exit.

With hope.

Maybe on the next turn they would answer.

How wrong I was.

I tried ten more times.

Ten more loops.

Until I couldn't go on.

I let myself fall in front of the door.

Tired.

Vanquished.

Staring blankly at it.

Fighting off sleep.

And then I fell asleep again.

When I woke up...

the door was open.

I couldn't believe it.

My mind tried to find an explanation.

I expected it to be another trick of the hallway.

Another deception.

I approached slowly.

Trying to control the anxiety.

With every step, I noticed a sweet scent: vanilla.

I peeked my head through the opening.

"Hello?"

The word came out almost as a whisper.

Nobody answered.

I entered cautiously.

I even placed a small piece of furniture to keep the door from closing.

I didn't want to get trapped in such a small space.

It was a simple apartment.

A small living room.

A tiny kitchen.

A single bedroom.

Empty.

The curtains remained drawn.

The record player I had heard so many times was there.

Turned off.

The small fireplace was still lit.

In front of it was a recliner.

A table with an ashtray.

A cigar rested on one of its edges, still lit.

A bottle of rum.

A poured glass.

And no one around.

I toured the apartment.

I didn't find anyone.

I opened a door; it was a closet.

Women's clothing.

A few belongings.

Nothing more.

The next door led to the bathroom.

A bathroom steeped in a scent of honey and oatmeal.

The shower was dripping slowly.

The drops echoed in the silence.

I tried to turn off the faucet.

I got a bit wet in the process.

Luckily there were several towels hanging.

I took the smallest one to dry my hands.

Then I wiped my face.

And there it was again.

That scent: vanilla.

I searched the whole room once more.

Nothing out of the ordinary.

Just a large bed covered in black sheets.

Alone.

Cold.

In an empty room.

And yet...

filled with melancholy.

The emptiness of a home.

The chill of silence.

Then I heard footsteps.

I ran toward the kitchen.

And I saw her.

Sitting by a small table.

A girl.

Joyful.

Smiling.

Swinging her feet like any little girl.

Happy.

A ghost.

Or perhaps...

the memory of someone.

I began to back away slowly.

I couldn't take it anymore.

Not anymore.

I ran.

I ran with all my strength toward the exit.

"This can't be the end!"

I crossed the threshold once more.

And returned to the hallway.

Back to the beginning.

We start again.

With a tired gaze and on my knees on the floor once more, I stood up slowly.

The place seemed normal again.

The air was cleaner.

Lighter.

The scent of vanilla had almost vanished.

The door to room 020 was open once more.

But inside it was empty.

No furniture.

No objects in the kitchen.

Nothing.

Empty.

Not even the girl was there.

I walked around the apartment for a while.

The empty bedroom.

The empty closet.

The empty bathroom.

The shower was still dripping.

And, why not?

I turned off the faucet once more with all my might.

A few drops fell on my hand.

This time there were no towels, so I had to dry them on my shirt.

With my hands pressed against my chest, I paused for a moment before leaving the bathroom.

I breathed.

I took a deep breath.

There was still some of that vanilla scent left.

So I breathed it all in.

I tried to keep it inside me as long as I could.

But I almost choked.

And I had to let it go.

That last breath.

That last gasp.

That last cry.

I left the room.

I turned off the light.

And I closed the door.

Then I turned off the kitchen light and paused again in the empty living room.

I walked over to the window.

I drew the curtains.

And I saw the city.

Its lights weakly illuminated the room.

For the first time, I could see the horizon.

The sun was about to rise.

I closed the curtains again.

I walked toward the door that led to the hallway.

And before leaving...

I looked at that place one last time.

For a flash, the room came to life.

The furniture returned.

The fire lit up again.

The music played once more.

The scent of vanilla filled the air.

But it was only a flash.

A damn, tiny flash.

I opened the door.

And turned back toward the empty room.

I turned off the light.

And left.

But before closing the door...

the ghost of the little girl appeared.

Part IV: The Dawn

She appeared to say goodbye as she closed the door.

I stood holding the handle for a few seconds.

Holding back tears.

Finally, I let go.

And I began to walk slowly toward the exit.

Without hope.

Without fear of what I might find next.

I simply crossed the threshold.

Back to the beginning.

Or so I thought.

With a sharp pain in my chest, I woke up with a start in my own bed.

The rain was still falling.

It was three in the morning.

I sat up trying to catch my breath.

Slowly, I regained my calm.

I got up.

I went straight to the bathroom.

I took off my wet clothes and stepped into the shower.

I let the water run all over my body.

The hot water calmed my heart.

And bit by bit, the tension began to fade.

I washed my face.

I washed my body.

I simply allowed the water to cover me.

When I finished, I turned off the faucet.

I reached out and grabbed a towel.

A large one.

Soft.

I dried myself completely and hung it back over the bathroom bar.

Then I saw it.

The other towel.

The small one.

Perfectly hung.

I took a deep breath.

With nostalgia.

And left the bathroom.

I put on clean clothes and walked out to the balcony.

The rain was beginning to stop.

The early morning breeze caressed the air.

And for the first time in a long time...

I felt like I had returned.

I stayed there until I saw the sun rise.

Still hidden among gray clouds.

Watching the streets covered in water.

In a beautiful dawn.